



Camouflaged in combat

This 1964 “Tiger Stripe” ARVN Marines shirt belonged to Master Sergeant Kendall, who served as the training command advisor to the South Vietnamese Marine Corps 1965–66.

Leadership

One of the major weaknesses of the ARVN was that senior officer positions were largely determined by patronage and there was little possibility of promotion of able soldiers into the officer class. The majority of commanders were Catholic, as was Diem, but most of the troops were Buddhist.

Corruption was endemic as the less-qualified officers pocketed funds intended for their units or kicked back funds to superiors to retain their positions. Reforms occurred under Vietnamization, but a toxic culture remained entrenched. Many of the top commanders adhered to vestiges of passive French defensive tactics, while their younger, American-trained juniors often favored aggressive operations—creating tension and confusion in the officer corps. A frequent charge was that the generals commanded from safe rear areas, rather than facing the enemy.

Life in the ranks

The enlisted men often lacked loyalty to their own government, felt pushed aside by the American commanders, and were ill-equipped and poorly trained. Yet, in the end they were called upon to fight to save their country. American officers sometimes declared that